

# **1<sup>st</sup> World Problems: A Jesus Approach in a Ronco World**

**2 Epiphany C**

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**Gospel: John 2:1-11**

*Turning water to wine at the wedding at Cana is described as the first of Jesus' signs. Through many such epiphanies, Jesus reveals that he bears God's creative power & joyful presence into the world.*

<sup>1</sup>On the third day there was a wedding in Cana of Galilee, & the mother of Jesus was there. <sup>2</sup>Jesus & his disciples had also been invited to the wedding. <sup>3</sup>When the wine gave out, the mother of Jesus said to him, "They have no wine." <sup>4</sup>& Jesus said to her, "Woman, what concern is that to you & to me? My hour has not yet come." <sup>5</sup>His mother said to the servants, "Do whatever he tells you." <sup>6</sup>Now standing there were six stone water jars for the Jewish rites of purification, each holding twenty or thirty gallons. <sup>7</sup>Jesus said to them, "Fill the jars with water." & they filled them up to the brim. <sup>8</sup>He said to them, "Now draw some out, & take it to the chief steward." So they took it. <sup>9</sup>When the steward tasted the water that had become wine, & did not know where it came from (though the servants who had drawn the water knew), the steward called the bridegroom <sup>10</sup>& said to him, "Everyone serves the good wine first, & then the inferior wine after the guests have become drunk. But you have kept the good wine until now." <sup>11</sup>Jesus did this, the first of his signs, in Cana of Galilee, & revealed his glory; & his disciples believed in him.

## **Introduction**

The Sundays after Epiphany continue to celebrate the revelation of God's glory to us as it was made known to the magi & to those on Jordan's banks at Jesus' baptism—today using wedding imagery. Our God rejoices over God's people as those being married rejoice over one another. By the power of the Spirit there are gifts galore for everyone. In Christ Jesus the best wine is saved for last. Taste & see.

## **Overview**

Epiphanies don't just happen in church—a sudden insight can lead to a "Eureka!" in scientific experiments, an "Aha!" in a detective's casework, a "Checkmate!" in a fierce chess game, & even a self-satisfied "Yes!" in Sudoku, crosswords, or finding a set of lost keys. So, too, epiphanies about the true nature of Christ come in a variety of words, actions, & places in our gospel readings during the Sundays after Epiphany.

First wise men from the east, then a dove from heaven & the voice of God, & now water into wine—all pointing to the glory & wonder of God-made-flesh. Just as we have been created & blessed with varieties of gifts, services, & activities, so too has God

created & blessed us with varieties of epiphanies throughout human history. In our world that so often relies on an us-versus-them mentality, can we see the rich tapestry of differences as part of God's glory? Will we be able to look past our traditions, our comfort zone, & our familiarities to see the glorious diversity of God's revelation? Are we open to an epiphany in any form so that we can in fact "do whatever he tells you" (John 2:5)?

## **Ideas**

John's gospel calls Jesus' wondrous deeds *signs*, not miracles. A sign, like water turning into gallons of wonderful wine, points to something bigger than itself. We don't get excited at a stop sign; the sign is merely part of the journey. A sign's value is determined within a larger context. The signs of Jesus have meaning in relationship to who Jesus is, fully human & fully God, & what is being revealed about God's own character through these signs. John uses signs to point out & explain how we receive grace upon grace from God through Jesus.

## **The Readings in the Bible**

### **[John 2:1-11](#)**

In the Mediterranean world of the late first century, the Dionysus cult was popular. According to the myth, Dionysus, the god of the grape harvest & the son of the high god Father Zeus, provided vast amounts of wine for his celebrative followers who then joined in ritual ecstasy. The Dionysian feast was celebrated on January 6, on which date some Christians came to read John 2. Although some interpreters resist seeing Dionysus behind the narrative of Cana, others view this explanation as the most likely impulse behind this Johannine messianic "sign," which is so markedly different from the miracles of divine healing. The jars contain about 175 gallons. The wedding occurs "on the third day," a hidden reference to the resurrection, & on the seventh day in this gospel's account of the new creation in Christ. For the fourth evangelist, it is Jesus Christ who is the true son of the true God. Yet the glory of this God will come on the cross, rather than in ritual ecstasy. As well, the fourth evangelist may be echoing the messianic poems by the Israelite prophets, in which plentiful wine will be served at the end of time.

### **[John 2:1-11](#)**

Christ establishes a new world order, symbolized by the details of this story: his attendance at a wedding, his messianic distance from his natural mother, his providing what the couple needs, the astonishing abundance of Christ's gifts, & the steward's words about "the good wine." Christ's "hour" is coming on the cross. The story

concludes with reference to the disciples' belief in Christ. Later, in John 15, Christ himself is the vine.

John uses symbolism extensively in his telling of the good news. He says in [20:31](#): “these [signs] are written so that you may come to believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, & that through believing you may have life in his name”. Our reading looks forward to Jesus' resurrection & glorification (“on the third day”, v. [1](#)), the Last Supper, & the messianic banquet expected at the end of time, when Christ comes again. The “mother of Jesus” appears for the first time in the gospel; the last time is when she stands at the foot of the cross. On both occasions, Jesus addresses her as “Woman” (v. [4](#)), a title roughly equivalent to *Madam* today: Jesus is guided in his ministry only by the Father's will (“my hour ...”). Mary's words in v. [5](#) suggest that she believes in Jesus, as she does at the foot of the cross. Jesus has the water jars filled completely (“to the brim”, v. [7](#)) with water. In Judaism, the “rites of purification” (v. [6](#), washing before & after eating) were ceremonial, but in totally transforming water into wine, Jesus replaces the old (Judaism) with the new; wine is a symbol originating in Christ. John presents “signs” (v. [11](#)) as aids to people in reaching his objectives ([20:31](#)). Jesus shows that God is present in his very nature (“his glory”).

### ***What Does the Text Say?***

3 features of this text deserve special attention. 1<sup>st</sup>, there is the wedding banquet itself. 2<sup>nd</sup> is the interaction between Mary & Jesus. 3<sup>rd</sup> is the replenishing of the wine. The decision to highlight the wedding banquet at Cana is John's way of signaling to us that, from the very outset of his earthly ministry, Jesus is the Christ whose every activity must be understood in relation to the revelation of his glory & messianic mission. As for the interaction between Mary & Jesus, there is room to interpret an element of humor. In verses 3-5, a quick exchange of words is peculiarly reminiscent of that awkward dilemma a child faces when put on the spot by a parent. Mary ignores Jesus' rebuke, & directly tells the servants at the banquet, “Do whatever he tells you” (v. 5). Mary is more than a pushy mom with excessive pride in her boy. When she says, “Do whatever he tells you,” Mary is not bragging, but showing faith in her son who also happens to be the Son of God. Mary's approach to Jesus concerning the wine demonstrates her firm belief that Jesus can save the situation. Finally, there is the matter of Jesus' changing the water into wine. This goes beyond symbolism. When Jesus changes water into wine, the transformation of the world according to God's holy purpose is becoming a reality through the presence of Jesus — the Word, the Son of God, the Messiah, the Christ.

**What Is Jesus Going to Change Next?** The reading describes Jesus' first miracle. It was a miracle of change & transformation. After having Jesus in her house for 30

years, Mary is astonished. Her son can change water into wine! Who knew?! The sermon is about whether we're willing to be subjects for Jesus' transforming power. What is Jesus going to change next? What does he need to change? What has he already changed?

## **Images in the Readings**

About the **175 gallons of wine**: Christian use of the Cana story usually has avoided any symbolic references to Dionysus or much honesty about the immense volume of wine created. Instead, the detail that this miracle occurs at a wedding has been interpreted as God's blessing of marriage as an example of the joy of those who live in Christ. Medieval celibate Christians welcomed any biblical passages that could serve the imagery of Christ's marriage to the church. Christians can use this delightful story as standing behind the weekly communion of the millions of believers who together drink the good wine of Jesus Christ. Grape juice was invented in 1869 by Thomas Welch. In antiquity, & still today in some places of the world, wine is safer to drink than water & is thus the standard drink at table. Churches that make grape juice an option at communion can still use the symbol of wine—its effect on the body of the person & on the body of the community—to suggest divine power & joy.

We are **married** to God: that is, we are chosen in love & bonded until death in mutual service & joy. For Christians, human marriage becomes a welcome metaphor for our relationship with God, &, conversely, the ideal relationship with God informs what we hope Christian marriage to be.

## **Life on the Earth**

In strong contrast to those religious spiritualities that avoid the things of creation as too distant from the divine, this story celebrates God's care for the married couple & God's delight in providing the goodness of wine. Over the centuries, churches have tried one thing & then another to minimize the bread & the wine of the messianic meal. Still today, in many churches, the bread is not recognizable as bread & grape juice replaces the wine. Perhaps communion with a fresh loaf, its aroma still in the air, & full swallows of fine wine can help us realize God's presence in the created earth itself.  
*We long for COVID to end.*

## **Comments from the Cloud of Witnesses**

Many of Christ's miracles, although at first obscure, have become clearer in the course of time. Then, those who saw the event from the very beginning narrated what had taken place: Jesus then made wine from water. But now, as well as then, Jesus continues to change our weak & unstable wills into that which is better. For there are, I

affirm, people who differ in nothing from water: they are cold, weak, & never stand firm. Let us bring those who are so afflicted to the Lord, that he may change their will to the quality of wine: that they no longer simply flow away, but that they be steadfast, & that they become to themselves & to others a source of comfort.

—*John Chrysostom (Chrysostom (c. AD 347–407) was an Eastern church father & archbishop of Constantinople. He is known for his [preaching](#) & [public speaking](#), his denunciation of [abuse of authority](#) by both ecclesiastical & political leaders.*

*(Thanks to SundaysandSeasons.com & montreal.anglican.org)*